and debarred her from contesting elections for the next six years. She challenged the verdict in the Supreme Court. On 24 June, Justice V.R. Krishna Iyer granted her a partial stay on the high court's order till her appeal was finally decided. She was allowed to remain as prime minster, but the order stated, 'she will neither participate in the proceedings in the Lok Sabha nor vote nor draw remuneration in her capacity as Member of the Lok Sabha'.

Though Indira Gandhi had won the fifth Lok Sabha elections held in March 1971 with two-thirds majority on the '*garibi hatao'* (remove poverty) plank, by 1974 signs of discontent had started manifesting in some states of India. Jayaprakash Narayan also known as JP or *'Loknayak'* (peoples leader), who had already given a call for a 'total revolution' at a rally in Patna, Bihar, on 4 June 1974, was increasingly putting pressure on Prime Minister Indira Gandhi to resign. Keeping that in view, West Bengal chief minister Siddhartha Shankar (S.S.) Ray, an old family friend of hers, in a handwritten letter dated 8 January 1975, [1] had suggested mass arrest of political leaders and suspension of fundamental rights as a measure to handle the deteriorating situation. She did not pay much heed to his advice all the time. In fact, she told Pranab Mukherjee (who, many years later, became president of India), one of her cabinet colleagues, that she was not even aware that constitutional provisions allowed for the declaration of a state of emergency on grounds of internal disturbance. According to Mukherjee, it was S.S. Ray who finally led her into taking that controversial and much reviled decision. [2]

As per information revealed to me by a close friend who was working in the office of the Chief of the Army Staff (COAS) at the time, COAS General T.N. Raina departed for a three day-tour of Bikaner on the morning of 25 June 1975. Gen. Raina had just finished his lunch at the local Army Mess in Bikaner when he received a call from New Delhi requesting him to return to headquarters immediately. He returned around 4.30 p.m. and attended a meeting at 1 Akbar Road (presumably with the prime minister) at 6.30 p.m. It is not known what actually transpired in that meeting. It appears that rattled by the prospect of an adverse outcome from JP's speech at a rally scheduled for later that same